VIT Bhopal University

VITyarthi E-Learning Platform

CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

Project Report

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Introduction

This report documents my work on the CSE0001 Digital Literacy course project at VIT Bhopal University. The project scenario places me in the role of a Student Digital Ambassador — a student representative responsible for helping peers navigate the digital world safely, professionally, and effectively.

Over the course of this project, I have completed five tasks that map directly to the five modules of the Digital Literacy course. These tasks involved creating an awareness infographic, building a professional digital portfolio, exploring coding and collaboration platforms, practising professional email communication, and researching cybercrime awareness. All deliverables are organized in a GitHub repository, which itself forms part of the submission.

This project has given me practical, hands-on exposure to tools and platforms that will be directly useful throughout my engineering degree and career. The following sections document each task in detail along with my personal reflections.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

What I Made

For Task 1, I created a one-page digital literacy awareness infographic titled 'Be Digitally Smart: A Student's Guide' using Canva, a free browser-based design tool available at canva.com. I chose Canva because it required no installation, offered a wide range of free templates and icons, and was easy to use even without any prior graphic design experience.

What the Infographic Shows

The infographic is divided into three main sections. The first section defines digital literacy — the ability to find, evaluate, create, and communicate information using digital tools in a responsible and effective manner. The second section covers safe internet practices, including using strong passwords, never sharing OTPs, checking for HTTPS on websites before entering any personal information, and logging out from shared or public devices. The third section addresses professional online presence — the importance of platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub, and the idea that our digital footprint is permanent.

The design uses a blue-and-white colour palette to convey trust and professionalism. Clean icons from Canva's free library accompany each section to make the content visually engaging and easy to scan.

Reflection

The most challenging part of creating this infographic was deciding what to include within the limited space of a single page. Digital literacy is a broad topic, and narrowing it down to three focused areas required me to think about what would be most

immediately useful for a first-year student. What I found most interesting was realising how many everyday actions — checking a website before logging in, using a separate email for different purposes — are actually components of digital literacy that I had never consciously thought about before.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

Platforms Set Up

For Task 2, I created or updated professional profiles on three platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle.

GitHub (github.com): GitHub is a platform for hosting code using version control (Git). It is used by developers and students worldwide to showcase projects, collaborate, and contribute to open-source software. I created a Profile README repository — a special repository named after my username — and added my name, branch, year, and a short statement about what I hope to learn.

LinkedIn (linkedin.com): LinkedIn is the world's largest professional networking platform, used for career building, job applications, and connecting with industry professionals. I filled in my Education section with my current degree, institution, and expected graduation year, and added a brief 'About' section.

Kaggle (kaggle.com): Kaggle is a platform for data science and machine learning, hosting datasets, competitions, and free learning courses. I set up a basic profile and explored the beginner courses available.

Future Plans

Over the next four years, I plan to use GitHub to store all my coding assignments and projects, progressively building a portfolio that I can show to recruiters. From my second year onwards, I intend to use LinkedIn to connect with seniors, attend virtual events, and explore internship opportunities. Kaggle will serve as my learning platform for data science and Python — subjects that are becoming increasingly relevant across all engineering disciplines. Setting up these profiles now, even in a minimal way, means I have a head start on building my professional identity before the placement season begins.

Task 3 – Coding & Collaboration Platforms

Part A – HackerRank

For the coding practice component, I chose HackerRank (hackerrank.com). I completed the 'Solve Me First' challenge, which is the introductory problem on the platform. The challenge requires reading two integers and returning their sum — a

simple task, but its real purpose is to familiarise new users with how HackerRank's input/output system works. I solved it using Python 3 and passed all test cases. This gave me confidence to explore more problems independently.

Part B – Google Forms Quiz

For the collaboration component, I created a five-question 'Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz' using Google Forms. The quiz covers: the definition of digital literacy, safe browsing practices, professional platforms for students, examples of cybercrime, and an open-ended question on the importance of email etiquette. The form includes both multiple choice questions (with clearly correct answers) and short answer questions that encourage students to think critically. The form is linked to a Google Sheet that automatically collects and organises responses.

Reflection

HackerRank will be an extremely useful tool as I progress through my B.Tech, particularly for preparing for placement aptitude tests and coding rounds. Companies like TCS, Infosys, and Wipro use HackerRank assessments in their hiring process. Google Forms, on the other hand, is a tool I can use immediately — for collecting peer feedback, conducting surveys for class projects, or running quizzes within my study group. The exercise of building this quiz also helped me consolidate what I had learned across all five modules.

Task 4 – Professional Email & Etiquette

Emails Written

For Task 4, I wrote two professional emails. The first was from a student to a professor requesting an extension on an assignment submission due to an overlapping examination schedule. The second was from a student to an internship coordinator expressing interest in a summer internship opportunity. Both emails follow a clear structure: a descriptive subject line, a professional greeting using the recipient's title and last name, a concise and polite body, and a formal sign-off with full contact details.

Social Media Checklist

I also created a Social Media Do's and Don'ts checklist covering seven Do's and seven Don'ts for responsible social media use as a college student. The checklist covers areas such as privacy settings, fact-checking before sharing, the permanence of digital footprints, and the importance of separating personal and professional accounts.

Communication Scenario

One real-world situation that demonstrates the consequences of poor digital communication is the case of students posting complaints about professors or examinations on public social media platforms. In several documented cases in India, students have faced disciplinary action or academic consequences after posting critical or disrespectful content about their institution or faculty on Twitter/X, Instagram, or WhatsApp groups where screenshots were shared. In most of these situations, the underlying concern — whether about exam difficulty or grading — was legitimate. What caused the problem was the public, emotional, and informal manner in which it

was expressed. The correct approach would have been to raise the concern privately through official channels such as a direct email to the professor or a formal grievance to the student affairs office. This experience taught me that the same message can have very different outcomes depending on the platform, tone, and audience chosen.

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness

Case Study: Phishing

For Task 5, I chose Phishing as my cybercrime type. Phishing is a form of social engineering in which attackers create convincing fake messages — typically emails, SMS, or WhatsApp messages — that impersonate trusted organisations such as banks, universities, or government portals. The goal is to trick the victim into clicking a link that leads to a fake website, where they enter their login credentials, OTP, or banking details. These details are then captured by the attacker and used for financial fraud or identity theft. Indian college students are frequently targeted through fake scholarship offer emails and fake UPI refund requests.

Prevention Checklist

I created a ten-point 'Stay Safe Online' checklist tailored for Indian college students, including two tips specifically related to UPI and financial safety. The checklist also includes information on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and the helpline number 1930.

Reflection

The most surprising thing I discovered while researching this topic was how technically convincing modern phishing websites are — they are often pixel-perfect replicas of real banking or university websites, complete with the same logo and layout. I had assumed it would be easy to tell a fake site from a real one, but this research showed me that even experienced users can be deceived. The one habit I will personally change as a result of this task is to never click on links received in messages — whether email, SMS, or WhatsApp — when they ask me to 'verify' my account or 'claim' a benefit. I will instead go directly to the official website by typing the address myself.

Conclusion

This project has been a genuinely valuable learning experience. Before starting, I had heard of most of these platforms but had never used them in an intentional or professional way. Over the course of the five tasks, I set up a digital identity that I am proud of, learned how to communicate professionally online, practised coding on an industry-standard platform, and became aware of the real threats that exist in the digital world.

The most important lesson I take away from this project is that digital literacy is not a skill you either have or lack — it is something you build continuously through practice and awareness. The GitHub repository I have created for this project will be the foundation of my professional portfolio for the next four years.

References

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- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal – cybercrime.gov.in
- Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) – cert-in.org.in
- Piktochart Infographic Tool – piktochart.com